

SYNTAXMASTER

Syntactic Theory
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10–September–2026



Taskmaster is a British game show where contestants attempt to complete a series of challenges or, more aptly, “tasks.” This game is inspired by one of them.¹

RULES AND INSTRUCTIONS

- You will be given a board divided into two columns, as well as a deck of cards.
- In the board, the column on the left is a series of concepts studied in *Introduction to Syntax* (1103).
- Each card, in turn, has data points. Each card should be uniquely paired with a concept on the left-hand side of the board. More specifically, the data points on a card illustrate the concept that it must be paired with.
- Each concept is labeled with a symbol (e.g. ☼ and 6a), while each card is labeled with a letter (e.g. P and R).
- The symbols comprise a cipher that you will use to decode a message. The pairings between a concept and a card give you the cipher. Your ultimate goal is to *decipher the message*.
- The message to be deciphered will be given to you only after you have completed all the concept–card pairings correctly.
- You cannot consult any materials, physical or digital.

EXAMPLE

Suppose you are given the following word to decode:



The first two concept–card pairings are done for you. These pairings tell us that the symbol ☼ corresponds to the letter P, while the symbol 6a corresponds to the letter R. This means that we can use these two letters to partially decode the word given:



Once you have completed all pairings, you will be able to fully decode the message.

Your time starts now.

¹Series 12, episode 4 (“The customised inhaler”), <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=NaGrc3fsvIU>, accessed: 2026–08–16. The wax seal above is inspired by the *Taskmaster*’s brand; it was generated with Google AI.

⊕ An R-expression cannot be bound.

- (P) a. He₁ congratulated Akbar*_{1/2}.
b. He₁ thinks [that Akbar*_{1/2} is a fan-favorite].

↻ Accidental homophony happens when there are two (or more) linguistic expressions (e.g. words or phrases) that are independent of each other, but which happen to have identical phonological forms.

- (R) I don't think anybody realizes how hard it is for women to work in the Postal Service. It is such a [mejɫ]-dominated industry.

↻ Auxiliaries and modals impose restrictions on the form of the verb that follows them.

Letter this symbol corresponds to:

🔒 The linear order in which a sentence is pronounced is illusory. Actually, a sentence comprises a hierarchical structure organized into constituents, with constituency being diagnosable by several tests.

Letter this symbol corresponds to:

😊 An intransitive predicate is unergative when its sole argument is external.

Letter this symbol corresponds to:

🔨 An intransitive predicate is unaccusative when its sole argument is internal.

Letter this symbol corresponds to:

💡 A transitive predicate selects two arguments, one internal and one external.

Letter this symbol corresponds to:

👉 Arguments selected by some predicate are obligatory, while adjuncts are optional.

Letter this symbol corresponds to:

 An anaphor requires not only binding, but, specifically, binding within its Binding Domain.

Letter this symbol corresponds to:

 A pronoun can be bound by some co-sentential antecedent, or it can be interpreted deictically (i.e. via the discourse context).

Letter this symbol corresponds to:

 A sentence is structurally ambiguous when the same set of words can be arranged into different hierarchical structures, each with its own meaning.

Letter this symbol corresponds to:

 A predicate imposes restrictions on the grammatical category of the arguments it selects.

Letter this symbol corresponds to:



A predicate imposes restrictions on the semantic properties of the arguments it selects.

Letter this symbol corresponds to:



The EPP is a principle that requires that the grammatical subject position be filled. This condition can be satisfied by movement or base-generation.

Letter this symbol corresponds to:



Binding requires both c-command and coindexation.

Letter this symbol corresponds to:

- (C) a. The student laughed (a loud laugh).
b. *the laughed student
c. The student laughed (*into smithereens).

- (Y) a. The vase broke (*a loud break).
b. the broken vase
c. The vase broke into smithereens.

- (I) a. Yueji tampered *(with a seal).
b. Yueji chose a letter (with a seal).

- (S) a. They₁ believe [_{TP} each other₁'s students to be the best candidates for the job].
b. *They₁ believe [_{CP} that each other₁'s students are the best candidates for the job].

- (D) a. [John₁ told Bill₂ [that I will meet him_{1/2} tomorrow]].
b. John₁ met with Bill₂ yesterday. [He_{1/2} will need a break].

- (F) A. Your dog was chasing a person on a bike.
B. This can't be true. My dog doesn't know how to ride a bike.

- (U) a. They talked [_{PP} about the plan].
*They talked [_{DP} the plan].
b. *They mentioned [_{PP} about the plan].
They mentioned [_{DP} the plan].

- (G) a. The chair worries about potential budgetary cuts.
b. #The desk worries about potential budgetary cuts.

- (E) a. * Arrived a man.
b. A man₁ arrived t_1 .
c. There arrived a man.

- (A) a. [John and Bill]₁ congratulated each other₁.
b. * [[John and Bill]₁'s teacher] congratulated each other₁.
c. * [John and Bill]₁ congratulated each other₂.

- (N) a. Siufa {broke/bought/decorated} a vase.
b. Siufa {met/embraced/chased} a dog.
c. Siufa {said/thinks/believes} that unlimited kibble should be available throughout the day.

- (L) a. The optician was concerned about **the child with a new pair of glasses**.
The optician was concerned about **them**.
b. The optician entrusted **the child with a new pair of glasses**.
* The optician entrusted **them**.

- (O) a. Siufa has {chased/*chasing/*chase} a dog.
b. Siufa is {*chased/chasing/*chase} a dog.
c. Siufa can {*chased/*chasing/chase} a dog.

Indicate which letter you paired with which symbol. If your answer is correct, you will receive the message that is decoded with this cipher.

<i>Symbol</i>	<i>Letter</i>
	P
	R
	
	
	
	
	
	
	
	
	
	
	
	
	

